

Ringed seal

Sleek swimmer

Length Up to 5 ft (1.5 m)

Weight Up to 236 lb (107 kg)

Habitat Pack ice

A typical true seal, with its almost fishlike body shape, the ringed seal is one of the most widespread Arctic species. Like other seals it can live in polar seas because it is insulated by thick layers of fat and a coat of dense fur. This allows the ringed seal to swim for hours in numbingly cold water in search of prey, and rest on the ice without freezing. The favorite prey of polar bears, this seal often stays near its breathing hole in case it needs to make a quick escape.



Ribbon seal

Distinctive pattern

Length Up to 7 ft (2.1 m)

Weight Up to 220 lb (100 kg)

Habitat Pack ice

Similar to the ringed seal, the far less common ribbon seal lives in the Bering Sea and nearby Arctic Ocean between Alaska and eastern Siberia. Adult males have black or very dark coats with a pattern of white or cream bands; females are paler, with a less obvious pattern. These seals breed on floating sea ice, and spend the rest of their lives hunting out at sea for fish, squid, and small animals such as shrimp.



Steller's sea lion

Visible ears

Length Male up to 10 ft (3 m)

Weight Male up to 1,248 lb (566 kg)

Habitat Coastal seas

Most sea lions and fur seals live further south, and include several species that live around Antarctica. But Steller's sea lion and the northern fur seal live and breed in the near-Arctic Bering Sea between Alaska and Siberia. Steller's sea lion is the

biggest of all the eared seals, which get their name from their visible ear flaps. It breeds in big colonies on rocky beaches, with the bigger males fighting each other over the females. It hunts mostly at night, preying on fish, as well as squid, crabs, and clams.



Hooded seal

Solitary hunter

Length Male up to 8 ft (2.4 m)

Weight Male up to 959 lb (435 kg)

Habitat Pack ice

The big hooded seal hunts large fish and squid deep below the surface in the Greenland Sea and far north Atlantic. Unlike most seals, it usually lives alone. Males are much bigger than females, and rival males often fight each other.

Harp seal

Breeding colonies

Length Up to 6 ft (1.8 m)

Weight Up to 287 lb (130 kg)

Habitat Pack ice

Named for the harp-shaped black marking on the silver-gray back of the adult, the harp seal is a slender, fast-swimming fish hunter. It spends most of its life at sea, forming big breeding colonies on the northern pack ice in late winter.

